

Backend Paired Coding Interview — StackExchange

Main Interview Loop · Panther Labs · Engineering

• 60 Minutes via Zoom • Backend Module · Technical • IC3 · IC4 · IC5 · IC6 • CoderPad IDE & AI Assist Only

This guide prepares you for the Backend Paired Coding interview at Panther. Read it carefully before your interview — it explains what to expect, what we're evaluating, and how to approach the session to show your best work.

ABOUT THIS INTERVIEW

This is a **60-minute live coding exercise** conducted via Zoom. You'll implement a backend function using the public StackExchange API and collaborate with a Panther engineer throughout. There's no single "right" solution — we're evaluating how you think, communicate, and build, not whether you produce the exact implementation we had in mind.

 **Required environment:** You may ONLY use **CoderPad's IDE and CoderPad's AI Assist**. Any online resources outside of CoderPad's AI Assist, or the Stack Exchange web API and its public documentation, are not permitted. External IDEs, Claude Code, GitHub Copilot, Cursor, ChatGPT, and all other AI tools outside CoderPad are **not allowed**.

Any programming language is allowed — change the language inside CoderPad using the language selector on the left panel.

 **Important:** The interviewer will share the CoderPad link, the full problem instructions, and the StackExchange API link via Zoom chat at the start of the interview. Take time to read everything before you start coding.

THE PROBLEM

Backend Function — StackExchange API

StackExchange API v2.3 · GET /search endpoint

You will be given the full instructions and a link to use the **StackExchange API v2.3** and the GET /search endpoint to complete a function. The complete problem statement and objectives will be shared at the start of the interview.

WHAT TO EXPECT & HOW TO SUCCEED



What We're Evaluating

7 dimensions · you'll collaborate with the interviewer throughout

Communication

Do you explain your approach before starting? Do you narrate key decisions as you code? Do you avoid going silent for long stretches?

Collaboration

Do you ask clarifying questions upfront? Do you engage the interviewer as a partner rather than working in isolation?

Coding Fluency / Efficiency

Is your code readable and well-structured? Do you use CoderPad's AI Assist effectively — prompting well and critically reviewing its output?

Data Structure

Do you choose appropriate data structures for the problem at hand?

Scalability

Do you think about how your solution would hold up at scale? Do you proactively consider design decisions that affect performance and reliability?

Debugging / Testing

Do you structure your solution for testing and leave time to test or document test scenarios at a minimum?

Feature Completeness

Does your function meet all requirements and return all required fields? Did you finish within the time limit?



How the Session Will Run

Be prepared for each of these phases

Intro You'll be introduced to the problem and expected to understand the full objectives for the complete solution.

Discuss First Prior to executing, walk through your approach with the interviewer — how you'd structure it and how you'd implement it. **Ask questions. Don't make assumptions.** Consider edge cases and ask for clarity before writing a single line.

Align Make sure you and the interviewer are aligned on your approach **before** you start coding.

Execute Implement your solution. **Communicate your thought process as you go** — silence is harder to evaluate than a candidate visibly working through a problem.

Test Structure your solution for testing and leave enough time. Ideally write unit tests; if not, document your reasoning and the scenarios you would test for at a minimum. Partial coverage is far better than nothing.

Debrief Walk through and discuss your solution once you've finished implementing. Discuss improvements, production considerations, and tradeoffs.

HOW THE 60 MINUTES SHOULD FLOW

Time	What to Do	Why It Matters
0–5 min	Read the problem carefully. Ask clarifying questions. Don't assume anything — confirm your understanding of the expected input, output format, and objectives.	Shows collaboration and that you don't jump straight to coding before understanding the problem.
5–15 min	Talk through your approach with the interviewer <i>before writing a single line of code</i> . Walk through your data structures, your overall strategy, and how you'll structure tests.	Communication is scored heavily. Interviewers want to see your reasoning, not just your output.

15–45 min	Implement your solution. Narrate your thought process as you go. Use CoderPad's AI Assist if helpful — but review every line before accepting it. If you hit a bug, talk through how you're debugging it.	Coding fluency, scalability thinking, and efficient AI use are all evaluated here.
45–55 min	Write unit tests or, if time is short, write detailed notes on the test scenarios you'd cover — edge cases, boundary conditions, empty result sets, API error responses.	Even partial testing signals engineering maturity. Notes are better than nothing.
55–60 min	Walk through your completed solution with the interviewer. Discuss what you'd improve, what you'd monitor in production, and any tradeoffs you made.	Shows production thinking and self-awareness.



How to Prepare

Practical advice for your best performance

BEFORE THE INTERVIEW

Set up CoderPad	You'll be coding entirely within CoderPad — no external IDE. Visit coderpad.io to familiarise yourself with the environment. You can switch languages using the selector on the left panel — you are not locked into any specific language.
Understand CoderPad's AI Assist	This is the only AI tool you may use. Use it to help generate or debug code — but read every suggestion carefully before accepting it. The AI Assist can miss important constraints or edge cases.
Think through test scenarios	Consider in advance: empty result sets, boundary conditions, API error responses, and general edge cases you might encounter.

DURING THE INTERVIEW

Collaborating with the interviewer	You will collaborate with the interviewer (an engineer) to complete the solution. We are evaluating: • Communication • Collaboration • Coding fluency / coding efficiency • Data structure • Scalability • Debugging / testing skills • Feature completeness
Permitted tools & resources	You can ONLY use CoderPad's IDE & AI assistant to complete the solution. Any online resources outside of CoderPad's AI assistant or the Stack Exchange web API and public documentation are not allowed.
What you'll be given	You will be given the instructions and a link to use the StackExchange API v2.3 GET /search endpoint to complete a function.
Session phases to expect	• Intro — understand the problem and the objectives for the complete solution. • Discuss before executing — walk the interviewer through how you'd approach and implement the solution. Ask questions, don't make assumptions, and surface edge cases before coding. • Align before coding — confirm you're aligned with the interviewer on your approach before you start. • Execute — implement and communicate your thought process throughout. • Test — structure for testing and leave enough time. Unit tests are ideal; if not, document your reasoning and scenarios at a minimum. • Debrief — discuss your solution, tradeoffs, and what you'd improve.
Using AI Assist effectively	Use CoderPad's AI Assist confidently — but own every line. The interviewer will observe whether you review output critically, catch issues, and adapt suggestions. Blindly

accepting AI output without understanding it is a negative signal.

When you're stuck

Think aloud. Say what you're seeing and how you're reasoning through it. Silence is harder to evaluate than a candidate visibly working through a problem.



Common Mistakes to Avoid

What separates strong candidates from the rest



Coding without discussing first

The most common way to lose points on collaboration and communication. Always talk through your plan with the interviewer and get alignment before you execute.



Not leaving time for testing

Feature completeness and testing are both scored. Structure your solution for testability and leave time — or at minimum document your test reasoning.



Assuming instead of asking

Use the discussion phase to ask questions and surface edge cases. Don't assume — confirm. Interviewers want to see you think before you build.



Using external AI tools

Only CoderPad's built-in AI Assist is permitted. Claude Code, Cursor, Copilot, ChatGPT, and any other external tool are not allowed. The interview must stay entirely within CoderPad.



Rubber-stamping CoderPad's AI Assist output

The AI Assist can make real mistakes on this problem. Review every suggestion carefully before using it. "It looked right" is not sufficient — you are responsible for the code you submit.



Key Things to Remember

Talk Before You Type

The interview starts the moment you read the problem. Explain your approach first — coding in silence is the most common way to lose points on collaboration and communication.

Ask Questions, Don't Assume

Use the discussion phase to surface edge cases and clarify objectives. Interviewers want to see that you think carefully about requirements before jumping into implementation.

CoderPad Only — No External Tools

You must code within CoderPad and use only CoderPad's AI Assist. No external IDEs, Claude Code, Copilot, Cursor, or ChatGPT. Any language is fine — switch it in the left panel.

AI Assist ≠ Auto-Pass

CoderPad's AI Assist can miss important constraints. The interviewer is evaluating whether you catch and correct those gaps — not whether the AI got it right.